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Textiles
reflect shifts
in cultures
and values.”

— Devdutt Pattanaik,
medic-turned-
mythologist

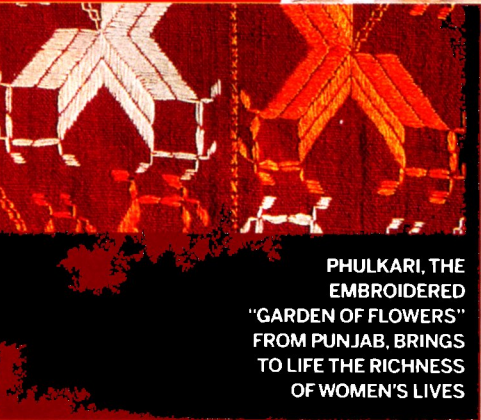
Garden of Happiness

A young girl would embroider her trousseau. Elders would smile and say, “She is making her garden of happiness.”



The Storyteller

Mohan Bhopa (extreme right), interprets Pabuji ka *phad*—a moral map on textile, based on the life of a 14th century war hero, for the roving camel-keepers



PHULKARI, THE
EMBROIDERED
“GARDEN OF FLOWERS”
FROM PUNJAB, BRINGS
TO LIFE THE RICHNESS
OF WOMEN'S LIVES

Tale of a Woman

The random appearance of colours or a change in pattern were not careless mistakes, but indicated significant events in the life of her family



birth, puberty, wedding, death—and mirrored a woman's joys and sorrows,” says Dhamija. “The random appearance of colours or a change in pattern were not careless mistakes, but indicated significant events in the life of her family.” The sudden introduction of red among yellow signified happiness: a birth or a marriage or the visit from a daughter. Black stood for sadness, while golden yellow marigolds for spring, love and fertility. Often, because a woman did not have access to the public sphere, her

imaginations took flights of fancy on the needle: things she desired, things she had not seen but heard of from itinerant storytellers. “It was a common sight to see women sitting in an open courtyard, embroidering and singing,” adds Dhamija. For instance, a young girl would embroider her trousseau, older women would smile and say, “Ah, she is embroidering her own garden of happiness.”

Resplendent in red, Mohan Bhopa plucks at his spike-fiddle called Ravanhattho, while his wife Patasi

Devi sings in rich, enveloping notes. All in honour of Pabuji, the 14th century war hero who gave the roving camel-keepers of Rajasthan a new identity and turned into a god. Bhopa is a storyteller-priest, carrying about Pabuji's “temple”—a painted *phad*-scroll about 15 ft in length—and reciting at all-night wakes. Today, he is not reading out a *phad*. Nor is his wife holding the customary oil-lamp to illuminate the details. Instead, he is busy smiling at author William Dalrymple, who made them a new